CONSOLATION WIN FOR THE CONGRESS

THE CONGRESS 'GOES LOCAL', FLIES UNDER THE MODI RADAR, AND MAXES OUT ON REBELLION IN THE BJP

BY ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

It's time for the upper reaches of Himachal Pradesh to receive the initial layers of seasonal snow, and meteorologists are keeping a hawk's eye on how the winter progresses. The days have been too warm till now—one is speaking purely of the weather here—but the mid-Himalayan state seems on course for a white New Year. Temperatures, meanwhile, were soaring to a merry high on Shimla's Ridge on December 8 as the local Congress throngs brought out the celebratory marigold garlands, beat the *nagada* and trumpeted a rare moment of triumph on the curved horns of the *ransingha*. Yes, Himachal Pradesh does tend to swing from one party to the other every five years—and it kept that pattern alive this time—but then a victory against the BJP does not come every day for the Congress. This one has come after four long years of electoral depression: the last time the Grand Old Party had won any assembly election on its own was in 2018. So, for the cadre and the leadership, the fine print could wait. For now, jubilation was in order. However small a portion of India's political map Himachal represents, and however slender the actual margin of votes, this seemed like spring.

There was some novelty on offer in other terms too... the loose outlines of a new strategic line. If the Congress set aside its self-destructive gene and emerged victorious in a closely contested battle, it was because the party changed its gameplan. The self-inflicted wounds of the past four years had owed primarily to one factor: overdependence on an often clueless central leadership. The gaps invariably showed in ticket distribution and in how the key points of electoral campaigns were plotted. That meant a kind of a structural aloofness from what made politics tick at the local level. More often than not, this translated into an inability to curb factionalism, and created airy manifestos that did not speak to the electorate's needs.



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WOMEN POWER Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra (right) with state party chief Pratibha Singh in Mandi